

CHAPTER FIVE

DISCIPLE OF DISCIPLINE

MY VISION NARROWED AS WE PULLED INTO THE DRIVEWAY AT THE crew cabin in Breckenridge, Colorado. It was just after four in the morning and dark as hell. I could barely see as I stepped carefully down the short staircase leading to the front door. Kish watched me, concerned, as I entered the house under my own power. I was hurting but holding it together, and she knew I wouldn't show any weakness in front of my team. In fact, she assumed I'd keep walking all the way through our bedroom on the ground floor and into the bathroom where she could help me get undressed and cleaned up. But the thin thread I'd been gripping tight to remain upright and presentable was fraying fast, and as soon as the guys were out of sight, it snapped. My knees buckled, and I fell to the bedroom floor.

Kish was right behind me. She closed the door and locked it, ripped the cover off the bed, and spread it on the floor beside me. Then did her best to reposition me onto the bedspread to give me some semblance of comfort. She had no clue that her attentiveness made me anything but comfortable.

Kish is such a neat freak she is borderline OCD. Dust, dirt, and the potential for germs get her radar pinging on high alert. She's the first to comment when there is something foul in the air, and here I was smelling like an old dog who had rolled in roadkill. My legs and feet were covered in mud and blood, my fingernails rimmed with dirt. A paste of filth and sweat coated my skin from toe to scalp. My breath was rapid, rancid, and shallow, and the mild tremors that had only been visible to Kish in the car because she was paying close

attention had become bone-rattling shivers. Then, my bowels groaned, and I knew it was about to get a whole lot worse.

This was nothing new for me. Ever since my first ultra, the San Diego One Day, the aftermath of every 100-mile race I'd completed included a tidal wave of pain and suffering, along with a humiliating loss of control of my most basic bodily functions. Kish knew that, but she had never experienced it firsthand, and I was nervous she wouldn't be able to handle it.

The two of us are very different people. Kish is not an outdoorsy motherfucker. If it weren't for me, she never would have heard of Leadville. Her idea of fun is spending the day on a pickleball court or golf course or chilling at a five-star resort. She's prissy as fuck. I'm a holdover beast from a different age, but when it comes to hard work and discipline, that's where we marry up. She keeps up in the gym and on the roads and trails, is a hard-charger when it comes to business, and understands my dedication to the grind in a way that no other woman—no other person—in my life ever has.

Yet, aside from that one night in the Nashville ER, she'd only ever seen me as capable of enduring and withstanding almost anything and everything with little to no help, and often on very little sleep. I'd rarely shown her any vulnerability, so how would she feel about me once she saw I wasn't even capable of wiping my own ass? Ashamed and embarrassed, I told her what was about to go down, and she looked horrified.

"Wait, David! Not on the duvet!"

"The what?" I asked, delirious.

"The duvet." I must have looked confused as hell because I'd never heard the word "duvet" in my entire fucked-up life. "You know, the comforter goes inside the duvet." Kish looked frazzled as she shook the snow-white linen beneath me, which, to her abject horror, was getting soaked through with my foul post-race marinade. "You're lying on it right now!"

"You mean the blanket?" I asked. She dashed out of the room without answering and returned with a black trash bag that she spread between me and the precious duvet like an open diaper. Only then did she tug my running shorts down to my thighs. My bowels unclenched, and an ungodly stench rose up around us.

As predicted, she had to wipe my behind because I couldn't move, and then she helped me up onto my knees so I could piss into some high-end decorative glass fruit bowl she'd found upstairs in the kitchen while she clenched her teeth and stressed about what this might do to her Airbnb rating.

After all of that, after she'd peeled the shoes and socks off my feet, cleaned me up the best she could, and cocooned me in that fucking duvet, my eyes rolled up behind my sagging eyelids. I wasn't sleeping. I was attempting to savor the uncontrollable shivers, the filth, my own sick stench, and the many flavors of pain.

The crushing agony in my hip flexors was searing. The only other time I'd ever felt anything like that was during the Wednesday night of my second Hell Week when I was roused after a five-minute power nap on the beach. Everyone else on my boat crew was getting a full hour, but not me. Psycho Pete, the instructor I hated the most, wanted a private audience. I remember trying to stand up with that maniac in my face. It felt like my hips were trapped in a vice. The only thing that would have eased the throb was curling up in the fetal position, so that's what I did in Breckenridge, tripping on how pain has the power to bring you back in time like nothing else. As I lay there, shivering and sweating at the same time, I could have sworn I was back on Coronado Island, getting wet and sandy.

Kish was terrified. She watched me, timed my arrhythmic breaths, and listened to my bones rattle as she mapped out emergency contingencies in her head. Was I in shock? Was I having some sort of altitude reaction? Breckenridge is at 9,600 feet. She was concerned my condition could deteriorate fast. But I wasn't worried about any of that. I knew that this was my old friend, breakdown. My final phase of ultra.

When I first got into endurance events, I loved the breakdown phase because the suffering made me feel alive and reminded me that I'd gone all-out. This time, I didn't relish it in the same way, but I knew that breakdown was a byproduct of an all-out effort and that if I explored the crevices of my mind, I would find valuable lessons, which tend to spill out with any unraveling. Most people prefer to avoid breakdowns like this because the suffering can be so overwhelming, it just might mark you forever. I embrace breakdown

and welcome the scarring. There is a hell of a lot of information in scar tissue.

Scars are proof that the past is real. Physical scars never go away, and when you look at them, they can bring you right back to a specific place in time. But the scar tissue that builds up around that old injury is weak. Professional fighters who've been hit in the face thousands of times bleed faster than those who have never been punched. Once you've been cut deep, you are forever vulnerable to bleeding.

The same is true for the mental and emotional scars that we all carry with us, the scars we cannot see. They might be invisible, but they affect us much more severely than physical scars. Mental and emotional scars are our weak spots, and they can open up just as easily as physical scars unless we do the work to strengthen them. If you haven't dealt with your scars, they can alter your life's path. You will be prone to failure during difficult physical and emotional situations, whether that's during an athletic event, at work, or in your home life, and eventually, you will land back in front of your mirror that never lies.

Breakdown is its own kind of mirror. Whatever you're made of is laid out in front of you clear and plain. Your history and mindset become a weathered old map ridged with your scars, and if you read them like an archeologist on a dig, you might uncover the code you need to rise again and become better and stronger. Because there is no transformation without breakdown, and there is always another evolution, another skin to shed, a better or deeper version of ourselves waiting to be revealed.

I did a quick inventory of my scars as I faded into that slippery headspace between waking and dreaming. Psycho Pete's voice trailed off, and another familiar yet faint voice that I couldn't quite place called out to me.

"David, wake up..." My memory convulsed and bled into my reality, and I couldn't tell where I was or what was real. "David," he said, gruffly, louder this time. "Time to get up, boy!"

It was the voice of my grandfather Sergeant Jack Gardner. Unlike those who embrace affectionate nicknames like Pop-Pop, Poppa, or Grandpa, he'd instructed me to call him Sgt. Jack, and that set the

tone for how things were going to be between us. Oh yes, he left more than a few scars etched in my brain, and he was shaking me awake just like old times.

* * *

It was the summer of 1983 when we staggered up his long gravel driveway and arrived on his doorstep under-slept, underfed, and with all our possessions crammed into black trash bags. My mother knocked on the door. While we waited, I scanned the yard. My grandparents had a big property—a full acre of land—including a wide, perfectly manicured lawn with train tracks running along one side. There wasn't a blade of green grass out of place and not a single weed in sight. That should have been my first warning.

While my dad was convinced that my grandparents had been behind our escape from Buffalo, he didn't witness our arrival or my grandmother Morna's wordless greeting on the front porch. She opened the door, rolled her eyes, and waved us inside. Sgt. Jack stood behind her with the expression of a drill instructor watching new recruits get off the bus with their long hair and beards, all wet behind the ears. He'd been a master sergeant in the Air Force and had retired years ago but was dressed in one of his flight suits. I didn't recognize the look on his face because I was a disoriented young pup all covered in scar tissue, but when I went to boot camp for the first time, I saw it again. That day in Brazil, though, he looked like a hero to me. I smiled. He did not smile back.

It felt good to be there anyway. I was happy to be anywhere but on Paradise Road, and they were relieved that we'd all gotten away from my father, but that didn't mean room, board, and babysitting would be free. The first bill came due before dawn the next morning when I was awakened by a stiff shake of my shoulders. I opened my eyes, and there was Sgt. Jack, still in uniform.

"Time to get up, boy," he said. "There's work to do." I wiped my eyes and glanced at my brother, who shrugged. It was still dark outside, we were exhausted from the trip, and as soon as Sgt. Jack

left the room, we fell back to sleep. The next wake-up call came in the form of glasses of cold water thrown in our faces. Two minutes later, we were in the garage where he kept his old metal desk from the military. On the corner of that desk was a yellow note pad. The top of the page was titled "Task List," dated and marked "0530." I had no clue what those numbers meant until Sgt. Jack explained that his house ran on military time.

That was the moment I realized that there would be no adjustment period and no coddling whatsoever. My grandparents never expressed basic sympathy for what we had been through. Sgt. Jack simply stared hard, went over the list, and walked us through the garage as if we were his new employees and needed to know where to find the rakes, hoes, hedge clippers, and his quiver of brooms and dustpans and how to operate and clean his manual lawn mower. He didn't care how we divided up the work, just that we got up and got to it on time. Each day started like that. With an unwelcome wake-up call, an itemized, military-time-stamped task list, and few, if any, words from the old man.

Sgt. Jack was half Black and half Native American, and though he was only five-foot-seven, he had a larger presence about him. He'd worked as a cook in the Air Force and still dressed in military attire every day. It was usually a flight suit or one of his Battle Dress Uniforms on weekdays. His crisp Dress Blues were reserved for church and all other formal occasions. Sgt. Jack took great pride in detailed stewardship. He cared about everything he owned. He had two separate two-car garages and four cars on the property, Cadillacs and Chevrolets from the midcentury. Like his well-tended house and garden, those cars were pristine.

Born in 1905, he came of age in Southern Indiana during the height of Jim Crow, when it was dangerous as hell to be a Black man in America and a wrong word or look could spark a lynch mob. His parents were poor, and he wasn't babied as a kid. His formal education ended in the fourth grade when he had to get a job to help support the family. So, when I landed in his house, he passed along what he'd learned. What they'd taught him worked as far as he was concerned. He had a military pension. He owned his house free and clear, same with every car in his garages, and he had money in the

bank. Sgt. Jack was squared the fuck away, and he got there with a self-reliance on detail and discipline.

Each morning, before he woke me up, he walked the perimeter of his property, surveying the lawn, several trees, and the long unpaved driveway blanketed in snow-white gravel. The house had two porches, one on either side, and he liked them swept and his rain gutters cleared of debris at all times because storms come down hard in that part of the country. Sgt. Jack couldn't stand seeing leaf litter, dust, or weeds. Everything had to be immaculate.

The daily task list was always at least ten tasks long. Sometimes, it stretched to over twenty. The first order of business in the morning was to sweep both porches, front and back. After that, I had to get out the rake and collect and bag any stray leaves that had fallen overnight. In the spring and summer, that wasn't a huge job, but in the fall, when the leaves turned, it took hours.

Hedges and grass grew like crazy during the humid Indiana summer, and that meant mowing the lawn manually in a perfect grid and clipping all the hedges almost daily. Weeds were always a problem in the summer, and as soon as they began poking through the gravel on the driveway, I had to get on my hands and knees and dig into the dirt to pull those fuckers free. The gravel dug into my skin, leaving scrapes and bruises. To me, it didn't feel a whole lot different from scraping gum off the skate-rink floor at first. In those early weeks, I took Sgt. Jack's tasks as a sign that no matter where I lived or who I lived with, I was bound to suffer at the hands of a bully. My scarred young mind was deep in the woe-is-me rinse cycle.

So was my brother's. He didn't last long on Sgt. Jack detail and retreated to Buffalo pretty quickly. Crazy to think that Buffalo seemed like the better option. I wasn't going anywhere, but that doesn't mean I enjoyed it. At first, I despised the man and attempted to rebel. He'd come shake me awake, and I wouldn't move. Then he'd splash water in my face, and I took that too. If I still didn't get up, he'd come to my bedside with a metal trash can lid and whack it with a wooden spoon right next to my ear until I was up and on my way to the garage to pick up my orders.

I didn't yet realize that Sgt. Jack was no Trunnis. He was my Mr. Miyagi. Not in the sense that each chore came with specific

instructions or that those instructions would manifest in skills that would deliver karate-tournament salvation. He never sat back and said, "I'm teaching you how to be a responsible young man." Yet, I learned valuable life lessons.

Many of us will meet people like Sgt. Jack in our lives, an elder or teacher who refuses to tell us what we want to hear in the way we want to hear it. When you're emotionally scarred like I was, any and every hard look or gruff reply, any order or mandate, can feel like a personal attack, and oftentimes, we tune them out to our own detriment. It took me a long time to understand that there wasn't anything personal about Sgt. Jack's approach or his list. It was all transactional.

His daughter—my mother—needed a place for us to stay, and in the real world, lodging isn't free. As far as Sgt. Jack was concerned, that daily task list was the nightly bill to be paid. Not that my mom gave it a second thought. She was busy with a full load of classes at the local university and two part-time jobs, a schedule she'd keep for the next six years until she graduated with a master's degree. The bill would have to be paid in my sweat.

Once school started, my work was divided into before- and after-school sessions, and there was rarely any respite. After I got home, schoolwork came first. Then, I had to complete all the tasks on the list correctly before I was allowed to play basketball with my friends. At first, I had no idea what doing a particular task correctly meant to the old man. The only direct feedback I got from him was a straight-faced nod, which meant he approved, or a shake of the head, which meant, "Try again."

I saw that a hell of a lot. His head shake of doom stalked me into my nightmares, where I would mow a lawn that never stopped growing out of control or attempt to clear rain gutters that were rimmed with saw-toothed blades that threatened to chop my fingers off.

All things being equal, I preferred to be outside. I considered most of the house a no-go zone because as badly as I felt I was being treated by Sgt. Jack, I much preferred him to Morna. She was also of mixed race and could pass for White if or when she needed to. She celebrated that fact by spraying the N-word around like an

Ecolab exterminator hunting for a hive of cockroaches. More often than not, her favorite word landed on my head. For all the racists I met in Brazil, nobody called me “nigger” more than sweet grandma Morna, which only heightened the feeling that I was their personal slave.

Months passed, and the tyranny did not relent. By then, I knew exactly what Sgt. Jack expected from me. I knew how to cut the grass, rake the leaves, and wash the cars the way he wanted, but I felt sorry for myself because few, if any, of my friends had to do chores at all, let alone complete a daily, military-grade task list. Plus, my grandparents still hadn’t demonstrated any empathy for what I’d been through during the first eight years of my life.

Clearly, they didn’t understand me. I was housed in their guestroom with dated furniture and wallpaper. I didn’t have basketball posters on the walls. I wasn’t given toys or cool sneakers or a stereo. Did they put out any effort to make that room more accommodating for a kid? Hell no! And the only way I could get back at them was by doing a half-assed job instead of working hard on the all-important tasks of the day. Of course, I was only victimizing myself.

If I wasn’t done before dinnertime, they’d call me in. The meals were not kid-friendly. There were no burgers or hot dogs. It was baked chicken or roast meats with sides of collard greens, chitlins, and cabbage. I was expected to clean my plate, whether I liked the food or not, and then go back out and finish whichever tasks remained undone. I often worked well past sundown.

I couldn’t understand why my grandparents treated me this way. The only explanation my jacked-up eight-year-old brain could find was that, like my father, they hated me and resented my presence in their home. Which is why in the early days, earning Sgt. Jack’s checkmark of approval meant nothing to me, and I sleepwalked through his tasks like a zombie. I figured any half-assed attempt was good enough. *Fuck it, and fuck him*, I thought. I hated the old bastard and didn’t care what he thought of me.

Six months later, though I still loathed the man, I changed my approach to the task list. I got up after the first wake-up call without delay. There would be no more early-morning baptisms for me.

Instead, I focused on the details Sgt. Jack always noticed and finished each job right the first time. That was the only way I'd get any free time to play basketball. However, my new approach produced an unexpected side effect as well: a sense of pride in a job well done. In fact, that sense of pride came to mean more to me than basketball time.

When I washed his car collection, a weekly assignment, I knew every drop of water had to be wiped away with a chamois before the first coat of wax. I used SOS pads to get the white walls gleaming and buffed the hell out of every panel. I also used Armor All on the dashboards and all the vinyl insides. I buffed the leather seats too. It bothered me if I saw streaks on the glass or chrome. I was annoyed if I missed a soiled spot or cut a corner here or there on any chore. I didn't know it at the time, but that was a sign that I was actually healing.

When a half-assed job doesn't bother you, it speaks volumes about the kind of person you are. And until you start feeling a sense of pride and self-respect in the work you do, no matter how small or overlooked those jobs might be, you will continue to half-ass your life. I knew I had every reason in the world to rebel and remain a lazy motherfucker. I also sensed that would only make me more miserable, so I adapted. But no matter how well I did or how fast I completed a given task, there were no atta' boys or weekly allowance. No ice cream cones or surprise gifts, hugs, or high fives. In Sgt. Jack's mind, I was finally doing what I should have been doing all along.

My grandparents weren't ice-cold to everyone. When my cousin came to stay for Christmas in 1983, there were hugs and kisses aplenty from both Morna and Sgt. Jack because, unlike my mother, his mom insisted they treat her child with affection, not military discipline. The gifts piled up too. There were toys and clothes and a barbecue where burgers and hot dogs were grilled to order, followed by bowls full of ice cream. Whatever he wanted and whenever he wanted it, my cousin got it.

"David, come on over here for a minute," Sgt. Jack said while I eyeballed my cousin Damien as he scarfed down his bowl of ice

cream. He'd been there for two days and had enjoyed more ice cream than I had in six months. "I have a gift for you too."

I followed him, almost shocked, until it became clear we were headed out into the garage as usual. Evidently, it was time to find out what a Christmas-morning task list looked like. Christmas was no different than the average Wednesday to my grandfather. He didn't care if it was your birthday or any other holiday. The work would not stop. I grabbed the sheet of paper off his desk as he wheeled over my Christmas present. It was a shiny new manual lawnmower with my initials monogrammed on the gleaming stainless-steel wheel hubs. There was snow on the ground, so I knew I didn't need to mow the lawn that morning, but there had been a sale on yard equipment at Western Auto, and the old man never could pass up a sale.

"Merry Christmas," he said with a grin. My cousin was being treated like a prince, and the old fucker brought me out to the garage to troll me. I guess I've had a lot of Merry Fucking Christmases in my life.

Two separate events would soon change how I saw Sgt. Jack forever. In the new year, my mom and I moved into our subsidized seven-dollar-a-month apartment in Lamplight Manor. The following summer, she enrolled me in summer school down the road. One day, after class let out, I walked home with a group of kids who lived nearby. One of them, a little girl named Meredith, lived down the street, and we covered the last stretch together. Her father happened to be sitting on their front porch drinking a beer when we got to her house, and as soon as he saw me, he put that beer down, leaned forward, stroked his beard, and glared at me like a mad dog.

Mind you, while my grandmother called me "nigger," I had never experienced any racism in public before. I simply thought he was mad at his daughter when he barked, "Meredith, get your ass inside!" I didn't think his stress had anything to do with me. Later that evening, he called my mom and warned her that he was in the Ku Klux Klan.

"Tell your son to leave my daughter alone," he said.

After she told him to go fuck himself, he said he would pay Sgt. Jack a visit. Everyone knew Sgt. Jack in Brazil, Indiana. He was friends with the mayor and other local leaders, who all considered

him to be a churchgoing patriot, a man of God and his word. He was proof that the American Dream was real, and in the minds of many racist White boys in Brazil, he was one of “the good ones.” Clearly, this fool thought Sgt. Jack would straighten her and me out. My mom smiled at the thought.

“Please do,” she said. Then she hung up and called her father.

When I saw Meredith’s dad again a few days later, he was on my grandparents’ front porch. He’d come by unannounced, but Sgt. Jack was prepared. He looped his pistol through his belt and wore it like a sidearm when he opened his front door. I was huddled inside behind my grandfather and around a corner but had a clear view when Meredith’s father noticed Sgt. Jack’s weapon and backed up a step. Sgt. Jack raised his chin another inch, looked the man dead in the eye, but didn’t say a word.

“Look, Jack,” the Klansman began, “if your grandson doesn’t stop walking home from school with my daughter, we are going to have some problems.”

“The only problem we’re gonna have,” Sgt. Jack said, “is a dead Klansman on my front porch if you don’t get off my property.”

I ran to the door in time to watch that man turn around, get back in his truck, and drive off. Then I looked over at Sgt. Jack, who nodded. It was the first time any adult had protected me from harm.

A few months later, I was in the driveway with Sgt. Jack and his friend Bill while they worked on my grandfather’s Cadillac. Those two tinkered with cars almost every day. If they weren’t changing spark plugs or checking oil, Sgt. Jack was flushing a radiator or steam cleaning an engine. When the day’s job was done, Bill slammed the steel hood down without realizing Sgt. Jack’s hands were still resting on the rim. The hood shattered fingers on both of his hands, but he didn’t make a sound.

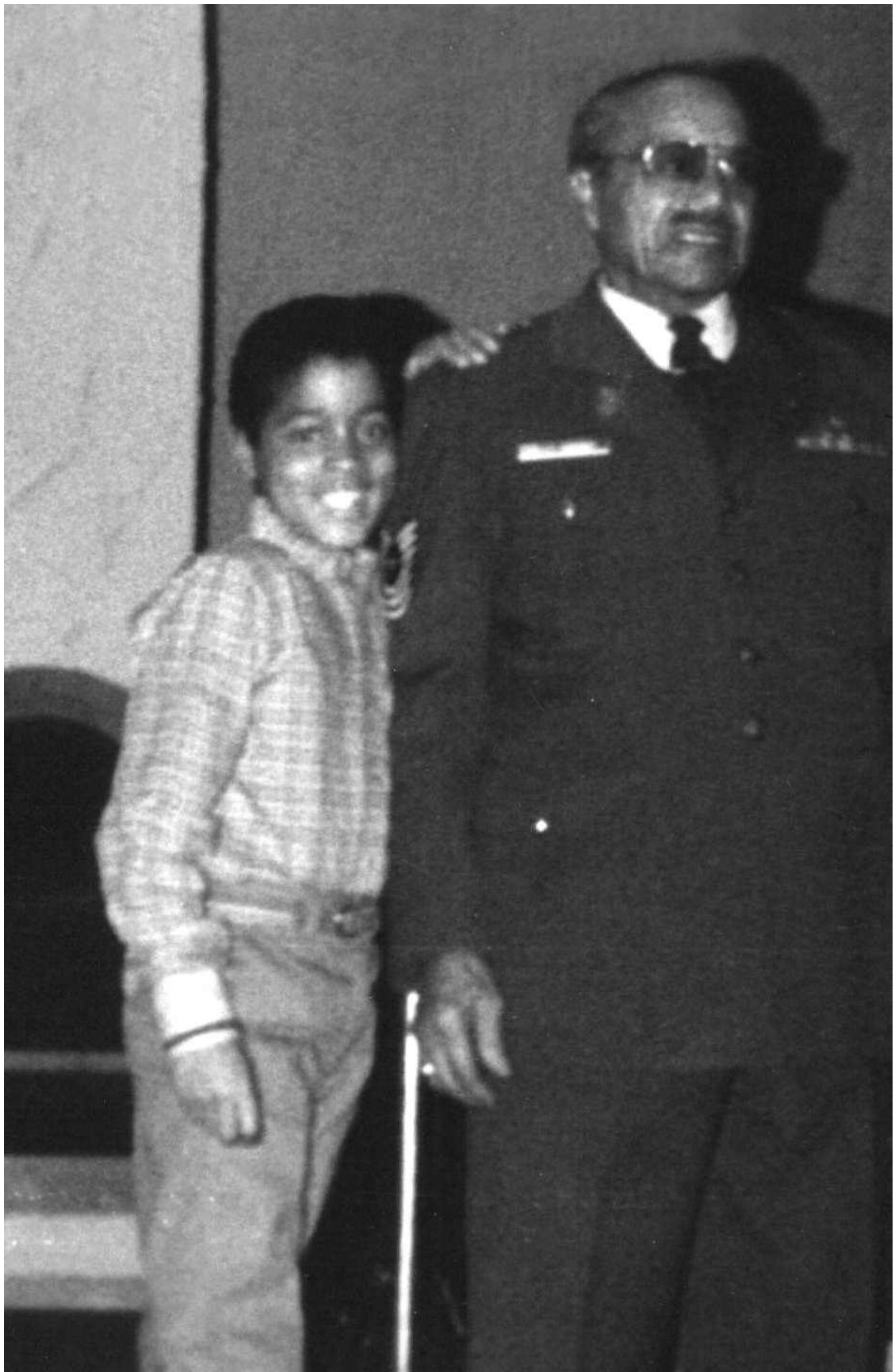
“Bill, lift the hood,” he said, calmly, still in complete control. The blood drained from Bill’s face when he realized what he’d done. He was so shook, it took a few seconds for him to jiggle the hood’s release. When he finally got it, Sgt. Jack pulled his bloody hands free, walked calmly into the house, and found my grandmother.

“Morna,” he said, “I think you’d better drive me to the hospital.”

Witnessing that changed me. I'd never been around such strength and composure. I didn't even know something like that was possible, and I thought if I could be as tough as him one day, all of the suffering at the hands of my father, the shoveling snow and gravel, the raking leaves and washing cars, the cleaning rain gutters, the clipping hedges, and the lawn mowing would be worth it. I was still struggling to learn, to trust, to feel good about myself, and to find meaning in all the pain, but by seeing how Sgt. Jack handled that situation, I learned that being tough could be my way out.

I don't mean my way out of Brazil. That wasn't top of mind yet. I was looking for a way out of my fragile, wounded state of mind. There's an old saying in the military, that "if you are stupid, you better be hard." Back then, I considered myself stupid. Partly because all that soft-ass scar tissue was still so fresh it was hard to focus on my schoolwork, and my response was simply to be lazy. If I failed because I didn't try, did I really fail? Then, I learned to cheat my way through. Sgt. Jack's way didn't involve whining, scheming, or feeling sorry for yourself. He was about gritting his teeth, taking pride in everything he did, and dealing head-on with whatever came his way.

For longer than I could remember, I'd felt neglected and ignored. I was bitter when my friends and cousin could play when they wanted to, watch television all day, and wear fresh gear to school. When would I ever get mine, I wondered? When would I get something for me and me alone? That day in the driveway was when I finally figured out that Sgt. Jack's example was the gift I'd been hoping for all along. It was more impressive and satisfying than any present could be, tastier than any hamburger or hot dog, and sweeter than an ice cream sundae. It was the best and most important day in my miserable life so far.



With my Mr. Miyagi

Sgt. Jack was a hard-ass teacher, but kids need hard-ass teachers sometimes. I know that might hurt your ears because things are different now. We are warned of the lasting effects of stress on children, and to compensate, parents strategize about how to make their children's lives comfortable and easy. But is the real world always comfortable? Is it easy? Life is not G-rated. We must prepare kids for the world as it is.

Our generation is training kids to become full-fledged members of Entitlement Nation, which ultimately makes them easy prey for the lions among us. Our ever-softening society doesn't just affect children. Adults fall into the same trap. Even those of us who have achieved great things. Every single one of us is just another frog in the soon-to-be-boiling water that is our soft-ass culture. We take unforeseen obstacles personally. We are ready to be outraged at all times by the evil bullshit of the world. Believe me, I know all about evil and have dealt with more bullshit than most, but if you catalog your scars to use them as excuses or a bargaining chip to make life easier for yourself, you've missed an opportunity to become better and grow stronger. Sgt. Jack knew what awaited me as an adult. He was preparing me for the grip of life. Whether he knew it or not, the man was training me to be a savage.

The evolutionary equation is the exact same for everybody. It doesn't matter who you are. You could be a young person looking to tap into your power and become great or a mid-life adult or senior who's never done a fucking thing but wants to achieve something before it's too late. Or maybe you've achieved a lot but are overcoming injury or illness or are simply uninspired and caught in emotional and physical quicksand. First, you must recognize that you have fallen off or are perpetually falling short. Next, accept that you are on your own. Nobody will come save you. They may show you an example, like Sgt. Jack did for me and I'm doing for you right now, but it will be up to you to do the work. Then, you must become a disciple of discipline.

Even after we moved into our own place, whenever my mom had to work late or go out of town, I'd spend the night at Sgt. Jack's, and

sure enough, there would be a wake-up call and a bill in the morning in the form of a task list. And yes, like my dad, Sgt. Jack was a mean old man who expected me to do as he said and work for free, but unlike Trunnis, he wrapped something valuable in the discipline he served, and whenever I put maximum focus to each task, I earned a sense of pride that I hadn't been able to find anywhere else.

But it didn't last.

Eventually, I grew into a rebellious teenager. I sagged my pants down, flipped the middle finger at authority, and was well on my way to flunking out. I had become a punk, but Sgt. Jack didn't try to tell me how to dress or act, beyond insisting that, when I come across an adult, I had better greet them with "sir" and "ma'am." And though he knew about each and every racial taunt and episode of vandalism I endured, he had no intention of stepping in to fight my battles anymore. I was almost grown, and they were my storms to navigate. Not his.

Like many disaffected teenagers, I wasn't living a mission-driven life. I was merely existing. I had become lazy, and my attention to detail was long gone because I didn't have that guy looking over my shoulder on a daily basis to keep me on point. The feeling of pride that I had back in the day working Sgt. Jack's property was nowhere to be found, but nobody considered this to be any kind of emergency. I was only seventeen, and even then, it was normal to give young kids plenty of space to do a whole lot of nothing much. We've all heard parents say, "He is only a teenager," or, "She's only in college," when explaining away bad habits or poor choices. The question is, when is the right time to start living instead of merely existing?

My time came when I received a letter informing me that my failing grades would keep me from graduating high school, which would also end my career in the Air Force before it started. The next day, I went back to Sgt. Jack and began staying over at his place more often. I asked for his task lists. I wanted to work in his yard. I craved discipline because I had a sense it might save me.

That's the beauty of discipline. It trumps everything. A lot of us are born with minimal talent, unhappy in our own skin and with the genetic makeup with which we were born. We have fucked-up

parents, grow up bullied and abused, or are diagnosed with learning disabilities. We hate our hometown, our teachers, our families, and damn near everything about ourselves. We wish we could be born again as some other motherfucker in some other time and place. Well, I am proof that rebirth is possible through discipline, which is the only thing capable of altering your DNA. It is the skeleton key that can get you past all the gatekeepers and into each and every room you wish to enter. Even the ones built to keep you the fuck out!

It's so easy to be great nowadays because so many people are focused on efficiency: getting the most for themselves with the least amount of time and effort. Let all of them leave the gym early, skip school, take sick days. Commit to becoming the motherfucker with a never-ending task list.

This is where you make up the difference in potential. By learning to maximize what you do have, you will not only level the playing field but also surpass those born with more natural ability and advantages than you. Let your hours become days, then weeks, then years of effort. Allow discipline to seep into your cells until work becomes a reflex as automatic as breathing. With discipline as your medium, your life will become a work of art.

Discipline builds mental endurance because when effort is your main priority, you stop looking for everything to be enjoyable. Our phones and social media have turned too many of us inside out with envy and greed as we get inundated with other people's success, their new cars and houses, big contracts, resort vacations, and romantic getaways. We see how much fun everyone else is having and feel like the world is passing us by, so we bitch about it and then wonder why we are not where we want to be.

When you become disciplined, you don't have time for that bullshit. Your insecurities become alarm bells reminding you that doing your chores or homework to the utmost of your ability and putting in extra time on the job or in the gym are requirements for a life well-lived. A drive for self-optimization and daily repetition will build your capacity for work and give you confidence that you can take on more. With discipline as your engine, your workload and output will double, then triple. What you won't see, at least not at

first, is the fact that your own personal evolution has begun to bear fruit. You won't see it because you'll be too busy taking action.

Discipline does not have a belief system. It transcends class, color, and gender. It cuts through all the noise and strife. If you think that you are behind the eight ball for whatever reason, discipline is the great equalizer. It erases all disadvantages. Nowadays, it doesn't matter where you are from or who you are; if you are disciplined, there will be no stopping you.

Believe me, I know none of that comes easy. I struggled to get up before the sun on that first morning back on Sgt. Jack detail. I hadn't dealt with a 0500 wake-up call in so long, it felt too sudden. I was lethargic as hell as the bed sucked me back into its cushy-ass arms. The pull to stay lazy was stronger than it had ever been.

That's how it works when you're trying to change. The call to remain complacent will only grow louder until you silence it with a pattern of behavior that leaves no doubt about your mission. Lucky for me, I knew the stakes were too high to fall into that trap, so high that I didn't have time to wake up slowly. I needed to knock out my chores before school so I could hit the books after I got home.

Still drowsy and dragging, I remembered that whenever I ran or played ball, I felt better afterward. I was just a dumb kid. I didn't know anything about the science of endorphins and how they trigger an energized and positive feeling in the body and brain after a workout. But I knew how I felt, and that was enough. I dropped down and hit a max set of push-ups. By the time I was done, I had the energy I needed to run to the garage, grab my task list, and get to work. That became my new pattern. Wake up earlier than I had to, do my max set of push-ups, and then get cracking.

It was during those days of struggle and striving, when I didn't know if I would actually graduate or be accepted by the Air Force, that I first realized I am at my best when I am a disciple of discipline. The further I got away from it, and from Sgt. Jack, the worse I became. While I still didn't like waking up early or most of the chores I had to do, those were the very things that turned me into someone I could be proud of.

I also knew Sgt. Jack wouldn't always be around to lead by example. He was already in his late eighties and had started to slow

down. Old age had crept up on him. He slept much more and didn't move very well, which meant it was time to learn how to hold myself accountable. His task lists had taught me how to prioritize and attack each day with a plan of action, so I started getting up before him. I'd do my push-ups, walk the perimeter of his property well before dawn, and assess what needed to be done. By the time he was at his desk sipping coffee, I was already working.

Once he saw that I took the initiative to not only do the tasks that would normally be on the list but identify additional work to be done, his lists shrank and then disappeared altogether. At home, Sgt. Jack's task lists evolved into my Accountability Mirror, which helped me build the habits necessary to graduate on time, pass the ASVAB, and enlist in the Air Force.

From then on, whenever I had a purpose or a task in front of me, I didn't consider it done until I'd completed it to the best of my ability. When that's the way you live your life, you no longer need a task list or an Accountability Mirror because when you see the grass is high, you cut the grass right then. If you're lagging behind in school or work, you study your ass off or stay late and take care of business. When it came time to lose one hundred pounds to become a SEAL, I knew exactly what I had to do. I had to tap back into being a disciple of discipline, but I didn't need a task list. Writing it down would have only cut into my workout time, and I didn't have a single minute to spare.

Once, those task lists were a burden. Today, I burn with an inner drive shaped by doing the shit I didn't want to do over and over again. And it won't let me relax until I've done what needs to be done every damn day.

My post-Leadville breakdown was physically challenging yet mentally exhilarating because it allowed me to bask in the power of my mind. The hard work it took to get back to the starting line of Leadville demanded that I go back to being the disciple of discipline Sgt. Jack helped create. Granted, I still don't know what his objective was. Was he trying to shine a path forward and make me better, or did he just want free labor? In the end, it didn't matter. It was up to me to interpret why he did it, what it meant, and spin it to create forward momentum.

It will always be up to you to find the lesson in every shitty situation and use it to become stronger, wiser, and better. No matter what comes down on your head, you must find a glimmer of light, remain positive, and never treat yourself as a victim. Especially if you intend to thrive in a harsh world where you have to work for everything that matters. I'm not talking about material things. I'm talking about self-respect, self-love, and self-mastery.

Minutes before waking up to the morning after Leadville, rank as fuck, with my shitty shorts still looped around my thighs, I flashed to one of the last times I saw Sgt. Jack alive. It was at my graduation from basic training in the Air Force. In spite of his poor health, he was adamant about attending, and as a World War II vet, he was given a VIP seat on the dais among the brass.

All the years I knew him, he'd never said, "Good job," to me. I never once heard him say, "I love you." But when they announced my name and I marched across that stage in my Dress Blues to officially become an airman like him, we locked eyes, and I watched one solitary tear snake down his cheek. Sgt. Jack was beaming, and it was obvious that he was proud as hell to be my grandfather.



Me and Sgt. Jack at graduation from basic training.

EVOLUTION NO. 5

THESE ARE THE FACTS, AND THEY ARE UNDISPUTED. YOUR PROBLEMS and your past aren't on anybody else's agenda. Not really. You may have a few people in your inner circle who care about what you're going through, but for the most part, no one gives a shit because they're dealing with their own issues and focused on their own lives.

I learned that the hard way. On our drive from Buffalo to 117 South McGuire Street in Brazil, Indiana when I was eight years old, I assumed I was going to walk into the biggest pity party of all time. I expected balloons, cake, ice cream, and big warm hugs. Instead, it was as if all the pain and terror never happened. Sgt. Jack didn't deal in pity. He was out to harden my shell, and that's exactly what he did.

Pity is a soothing balm that turns toxic. At first, when your family and friends commiserate with you and validate the reasons you have for grumbling about your circumstances, it lands like sympathy. But the more comfort pity brings you, the more external validation you'll crave and the less independent you will become. Which will make it that much more difficult for you to gain any traction in life. That's the vicious cycle of pity. It saps self-esteem and inner strength, which makes it harder to succeed, and with each subsequent failure, you will be more tempted to pity yourself.

Look, I get it. Life isn't fair or easy. A lot of us are doing a job that we don't want to do. We feel we are above the tasks coming our way and that the world, or God, or the fates have sentenced us to live in a box we do not belong in. When I was a night-shift security guard at a local hospital, I felt that work was beneath me, so I showed up every night with a voice in my head screaming, *I don't want to be here!* And that infected everything about my life. I ate my feelings,

blew up, and slipped into a deep depression. I wanted a different life, but my shitty attitude made it impossible to create one.

Every minute you spend feeling sorry for yourself is another minute not getting better, another morning you miss at the gym, another evening wasted without studying. Another day burned when you didn't make any progress toward your dreams, ambitions, and deepest desires. The ones you've had in your head and heart your entire life.

Every minute you spend feeling sorry for yourself is another minute spent in the dungeon thinking about what you lost or the opportunities that have been snatched away or squandered, which inevitably leads to the Great Depression. When you are depressed, you are likely to believe that nobody understands you or your plight. I used to think that way. But when Sgt. Jack banged that trash can lid inches from my ear in the morning, he was telling me I wasn't the only little boy who got whipped or suffered from toxic stress. Sometimes, the emotions we feel are a product of a fucked-up past. Sometimes, we just don't want to get up at 0500 and do hours of chores before school because it sucks. Sgt. Jack expected me to perform no matter what I'd been through or what time it was.

In response, my feelings got hurt. I stalled getting out of bed until the last possible moment and half-assed my way through my mornings as part of a mindless, mopey rebellion. He didn't give a rat's ass. That grass still needed to be cut, the leaves needed to be raked, and the weeds needed to be pulled. No matter how much I belly-ached, this work needed to get done, and it would get done by me. My feelings were costing me a ton of time because no matter how I felt, there was a task in front of me, and that's all that mattered in the present moment.

The only thing that ever matters is the present moment. Yet too many people let their depression or regret hijack their day. They let their feelings about the past hijack their lives. Perhaps their fiancé left them at the altar, or they got fired without cause. Guess what? One day, they will pan back and realize that nobody fucking cared about any of that but them. I don't care what you've been through. I can feel bad for you. I can have sympathy for you, but my sympathy won't get you anywhere. When I was a young, damaged kid, feeling

sorry for myself didn't help me. What helped was cleaning those whitewalls right the first time.

We cannot get time back, so we must be minute hoarders. The earlier I get up, the more I do. The less time I stay in pity-party-feel-sorry-for-myself land, the stronger I become and the more daylight I see between me and everyone else. When you separate yourself from the pack by cultivating the values and priorities that lead to greatness, mountains of adversity and hardship become speed bumps, and that makes it easier to adapt to the road ahead and build the new life or sense of self you crave.

When I went to live with Sgt. Jack, I was forced to adapt extremely fast. Everyone was hard on me my whole life, but I came out of all that with lessons learned that stuck with me. Those who learn to adapt survive and thrive. Don't feel sorry for yourself. Get strategic. Attack the problem.

When you adapt, you will begin to see everything that comes your way as a stepping stone on your progression toward a higher plane. High-paying, esteemed jobs are generally not entry level. You have to start somewhere, but most people see the thankless tasks that must be completed in order to advance as burdens instead of opportunities. That makes it impossible for them to learn. You've got to find the lesson in every shitty task or low-wage job. That requires humility. I wasn't humble enough to appreciate my experience in security, so my attitude was foul as fuck. I thought I deserved much better, oblivious to the fact that almost everybody starts at the bottom and, from there, it's attitude and action that determine the future.

Humility is the antidote to self-pity. It keeps you rooted in reality and your emotions in check. I'm not suggesting you should be satisfied with an entry-level job. I'm never satisfied, but you must appreciate what you have while staying hungry enough to learn everything you can. You need to learn to wash the dishes, flip the burgers, sweat over the deep fryer, sweep up the job site, work in the mailroom, and answer the phones. That's how you build proficiency. It's important to learn every aspect of any business before you move up. You can't rise if you're weighed down by bitterness and entitlement. Humility hardens your spine and encourages you to

stand tall, secure in yourself no matter what anyone else thinks. And that has tremendous value.

I once heard a story about a Master Sergeant in the Army named William Crawford that exemplifies the power of humility. He retired in 1967 and took a job as a janitor at the Air Force Academy in Colorado Springs. The cadets he cleaned up after paid him little mind, in part because he was reportedly painfully shy but also because these cadets were elite students on an officer track, and Master Sergeant Crawford was just a janitor. Or so they thought. They had no clue that he was also a war hero.

In September 1943, the 36th Infantry Division was getting blitzed by German machine-gun fire and mortars during a pivotal World War II battle for a piece of Italian real estate known as Hill 424. The Americans were pinned down with no escape route until Crawford spied three machine-gun nests and crawled beneath rivers of bullets to toss a grenade into each of them. His bravery saved lives and allowed his company to advance to safe ground, and after the third direct hit, the Germans abandoned Hill 424, but not before they took Crawford prisoner.

Presumed to be killed in action, tales of his heroism spread among infantrymen and traveled up the chain of command. In 1944, he was awarded the Medal of Honor, the highest decoration in the U.S. military. Because everyone thought he was dead, his father accepted the medal on his behalf. Later that same year, he was found in a liberated POW camp, oblivious to the hype surrounding his name.

In 1976, an Academy cadet and his roommate read about that battle and connected the dots. Their humble janitor had won the Medal of Honor! Can you imagine what went through their heads? The Medal of Honor speaks to everything a military person reveres. Not the medal itself, but the courage and selflessness inside the human being who earned that medal. Those students wanted to be him, and there he was, mopping their floors and cleaning their bathrooms every day. Master Sergeant Crawford was a walking lesson in self-esteem, courage, character, and, especially, humility.

The way I see it, Master Sergeant William Crawford had figured it the fuck out. The Medal of Honor didn't change him. He rose to

prominence by staying humble and risking his own life to save others and retired into the service of others. It was never about him, and that gave him strength.

People who feel sorry for themselves are obsessed with their own problems and their own fate. Is that really much different than the greedy and egotistical people who want to feel better than everybody else? The higher I climb in my life, the more I realize how much I need to mop that floor. Because that's where all the knowledge is. There is no grit at the top, no tests of resolve in steak dinners, five-star hotels, or spa treatments. Once you make it in this world, you have to freefall back to the bottom in some way to keep learning and growing.

I call this "trained humility." It's a shedding of your skin that allows you to take on a mission that no one else can see and do whatever needs to be done next. Trained humility is service but also strength. Because, when you are humble enough to remember that you'll never know it all, each lesson you learn only makes you hungrier to learn more, and that will put you on a path that guarantees you will grow all the way to the grave.

Continued growth only comes when you are willing to be humble.
#TrainedHumility #NeverFinished